

Next, find healthy emotion-focused coping mechanisms that work for you. These are true forms of self-care, and they don't have to cost money. They can even help in achieving some high-level internal needs. A good example is exercise.

Exercise allows us creativity to find a form of movement that works best for us, see a tangible example of our capacity for improvement, and can often be a place for building relationships. In a study² to see what best alleviates stress hormones in the brain, mice were placed under stress and then given one hour per day of running on a treadmill. The results found that the exercise decreased anxiety-like behaviors immediately and improved their resilience to subsequent stressors in future tests.

Meditation is another. It strengthens our connection to a higher power and the world around us, and there's plenty of research³ that has established meditation as lowering resting heart rate and blood pressure, helping you sleep better, and helping you be more creative and patient (that alone will help you spend better!).

When our friend Brittany wanted to stop eating out (for health and spending reasons), she first recognized she was using it as a coping mechanism and then experimented to find a healthier one. "When something was making me anxious, I coped by making myself a little coupon book of stuff I liked that did not involve money or unhealthy food: a walk, twenty minutes at the library, a bubble bath, etc. It sounds so silly, but it actually worked!"

Again, experiment to find what works best for you. Here are a few more options to get you started:

Practicing art

Reading

Prayer

Playing sports

Spending time in nature

Spending time with friends

You need an arsenal of healthy coping mechanisms at your disposal, because while some are more powerful than others, those may not always be at your disposal when you need them. Remember, especially when these